

Content Filtering Governance Brief

Ardent ISD | Leadership Framework

Purpose

Content filtering is both a technical service and a governance responsibility. The technology department operates the filtering platform, but decisions about instructional access, policy, legal requirements, student safety, and exceptions should not rest with one technician or one department acting alone.

Decision Roles

Decision Area	Primary Role	Partners / Escalation
Technical operation and reliability	Technology Services	Network/security specialists; vendor support
Category configuration and standard rules	Technology leadership	Curriculum, student services, administration
Instructional exceptions	Campus/curriculum process	Technology for implementation; administration for disputed requests
Policy alignment	District administration	Board policy resources and legal counsel as needed
CIPA-related compliance review	District leadership	E-Rate lead/consultant, legal/policy resources, Technology
Security-driven blocking	Technology/security	CTO, cybersecurity specialists, executive leadership as appropriate
Appeals / contested access	Defined district process	Campus leadership, curriculum, student services, legal/policy resources as needed

Leadership Principles

- Filtering decisions should be documented and reviewable.
- Technical staff should not be required to resolve policy or legal disputes independently.
- Overblocking can interfere with teaching and learning; underblocking can create safety, policy, and compliance concerns.
- Changes should be evaluated for impact on students, staff, testing, accessibility, and legitimate instructional use.
- The district should maintain a clear exception and escalation process.

Annual Review Questions

1. Is the district's internet safety policy current and aligned with its filtering practices?
2. Are filtering categories and exception processes documented?
3. Are instructional complaints concentrated in particular categories or services?
4. Does the district know who may approve exceptions and how quickly?
5. Are filtering changes tested for unintended effects?
6. Are required E-Rate/CIPA documentation responsibilities assigned to the correct district roles?

CTO Communication Line

When discussing filtering with cabinet or the board, explain **the purpose, decision process, evidence, and tradeoffs**. Avoid reducing the conversation to a list of blocked categories.

Reference Points

- [CoSN IT Management Resources](#) - K-12 technology operations and leadership resources.
- [USAC E-Rate Program](#) - Federal E-Rate program information for schools and libraries.
- [SETDA Infrastructure for the Future](#) - Guidance for future-ready broadband and infrastructure planning.
- [Future Ready Schools Frameworks](#) - Systems-oriented planning connecting infrastructure, learning, leadership, budget, and equity.

Leadership use: This document is designed to support district-level review, discussion, and decision-making. Technical validation, procurement review, legal review, or compliance review should be completed by the appropriate district specialists when applicable.